

Thinking machine

Indian Institute of Information Technology Pune

Hackathon Event Report

Academic Year 2025–26

Event Snapshot

Event Name	Thinking Machine
Organising Body	Indian Institute of Information Technology, Pune
Dates	10 February – 13 February 2026
Venue	IIIT Pune Campus (Offline Final) + Online (Round 1)
Format	Hybrid (Online Round 1 → Offline Final)
Total Registrations	333
Complete Registrations	82
Submissions (Unstop)	43
Finalist Teams	Top 6 teams (offline final)
Prize Pool	₹17500
Domain	Machine Learning Engineering & Applied AI

1. Overview

Thinking Machine was a national-level AI hackathon hosted by the Indian Institute of Information Technology, Pune (IIIT Pune), challenging participants to develop impactful AI-powered solutions through an intensive four-day competition. The event was conducted in two stages: an online submission round followed by an offline grand finale at the IIIT Pune campus. The hackathon attracted enthusiastic participation from students representing premier engineering institutions across India. Participants came from leading institutes including Walchand College of Engineering (Sangli), PCCOE (Pimpri Chinchwad College of Engineering, Pune), NIT Warangal, COEP Technological University (Pune), Pune Institute of Computer Technology (PICT), MIT World Peace University (Pune), Vishwakarma Institute of Technology (Pune), Sardar Patel Institute of Technology (Mumbai), K. J. Somaiya College of Engineering (Mumbai), Dwarkadas J. Sanghvi College of Engineering (Mumbai), Thakur College of Engineering and Technology (Mumbai), Vellore Institute of Technology (VIT), SRM Institute of Science and Technology, and several other reputed state and private universities. With a total of **333 registrations**, **82 complete team registrations**, and **43 project submissions** through the Unstop platform, the event demonstrated strong enthusiasm for innovation and applied Artificial Intelligence. Following a rigorous evaluation process, the **top six performing teams** from the online round were shortlisted to compete in the offline finale, where they presented their solutions before an expert jury panel at IIIT Pune. The event successfully provided a platform for students to showcase technical creativity, collaborate across disciplines, and address real-world challenges using cutting-edge AI and Machine Learning technologies. The diversity of participating institutions reflected the growing interest in AI-driven innovation among India's engineering and technology community.

2. Objectives

- To promote innovation in Artificial Intelligence and Machine Learning among students through a competitive, problem-driven hackathon format.
- To provide students with hands-on experience building AI-powered prototypes addressing real-world challenges in Healthcare, EdTech, FinTech, and Retail & E-Commerce.
- To identify and recognise top talent in AI and ML from institutions across India.
- To foster a culture of research-oriented thinking and applied AI development within IIIT Pune and the broader student community.
- To equip student organizers with practical experience in event management, outreach, and coordination.

3. Event Format

3.1. Stage 1 — Online Submission Round

Submission Window: 4 February 2026 (8:00 PM IST) — 11 February 2026 (3:00 PM IST)

All participating teams submitted their solutions via the Unstop platform during the online round. The submission package required:

- Pitch Deck explaining the idea and product (PPT or PDF format)
- Source code hosted in a public GitHub repository
- Strict deadline adherence — no late submissions were entertained

3.2. Stage 2 — Offline Final Round

Date: 13 February 2026 (10:00 AM – 5:00 PM IST) | Venue: IIIT Pune Campus

The top 6 teams from the preliminary round were invited to the IIIT Pune campus for the in-person final. Teams delivered live presentations before a panel of jury members, showcasing their fully developed AI prototypes and demonstrating their technical depth, innovation, and real-world viability.



4. Problem Domains

Participating teams chose from four broad AI application domains, each with suggested problem statements:

4.1. Healthcare AI — Code for a Healthier Tomorrow

Focused on using AI to improve patient outcomes, streamline hospital management, and democratise access to medical advice. Key problem areas included:

- Diagnostic Tools: Multi-disease prediction models, Medical Image Analysis (X-Ray/MRI anomaly detection)
- Virtual Assistance: Mental health support chatbots, Symptom checkers, Personalised diet/fitness recommendation engines
- Management: Automated doctor appointment scheduling, Blood bank donor matching, Medicine inventory tracking

4.2. EdTech AI — Reinventing the Classroom

Addressed the evolution from one-size-fits-all education to personalised learning. Key problem areas included:

- Smart Campus: Facial recognition-based attendance, Automated proctoring, Library automation
- Learning Aids: Lecture note summarisers, Doubt-solving bots (RAG-based), Vernacular language translators
- Career Tech: AI-powered resume screeners, Automated quiz generators, Personalised career roadmap creators

4.3. FinTech AI — Secure, Smart & Scalable Finance

Focused on financial literacy, security, and intelligent money management tools. Key problem areas included:

- Predictive Analytics: Stock price prediction models, Crypto portfolio trackers, Sales forecasting engines
- Security: Credit card fraud detection, Loan eligibility predictors, Fake currency detection
- Personal Finance: Smart expense trackers, Budgeting assistants, Automated tax/GST calculators

4.4. Retail & E-Commerce AI — The Future of Commerce

Addressed personalisation and operational optimisation in digital retail. Key problem areas included:

- Discovery: Product recommendation systems, Visual search tools, Customer segmentation models
- Experience: Virtual try-on solutions, Customer support chatbots, Sentiment analysis of product reviews
- Operations: Fake review detection, Price comparison tools, Inventory demand prediction

5. Participation Statistics

Total Registrations	333
Complete Registrations	82
Submissions via Unstop	43

Teams Advancing to Final	6 (top performers from Round 1)
Round 1 Format	Online — Pitch Deck + GitHub Repository
Round 2 Format	Offline — Live Presentation at IIIT Pune Campus
Team Size	2 – 4 Members (solo participation not allowed)
Eligibility	Students and enthusiasts from all institutions

6. Prizes & Recognition

Total Prize Pool	₹25,000
Winner	₹10,000
Finalists	Certificates awarded to all finalist teams

All finalist teams received certificates of participation. The prize distribution recognised technical excellence, innovation, and real-world applicability of the AI solutions developed during the hackathon.





7. Rules & Guidelines

7.1. Eligibility

- Teams must consist of 2 to 4 members (solo participation not allowed).
- Students and enthusiasts from all institutions were welcome.
- One person could only be part of one team.

7.2. Project Requirements

- Projects must be started during the hackathon period.
- Use of existing code libraries and frameworks was allowed.
- Pre-built complete projects were strictly prohibited.
- All code must be original or properly attributed.
- Project must address one of the given problem domains.

7.3. Code of Conduct

- All participants, organizers, mentors, and judges were to be treated with respect.
- No harassment, discrimination, or inappropriate behaviour was tolerated.
- Participants were required to maintain a collaborative and inclusive environment.
- Violations were to be reported to organizers immediately.

7.4. Prohibited Actions

- Plagiarism or copying others' work
- Cheating or unfair practices

- Violating data privacy laws
- Submitting offensive content
- Starting a project before the hackathon officially began

8. Conclusion

Thinking Machine was successfully conducted as a national-level AI hackathon that showcased the depth of talent and innovation among student communities across India. The event attracted 333 registrations and 43 valid submissions via the Unstop platform, reflecting strong interest in applied Artificial Intelligence across domains of Healthcare, EdTech, FinTech, and Retail.

The hybrid format — combining an accessible online round with a rigorous in-person final — ensured broad participation while maintaining high competitive standards. The top 6 finalist teams presented fully developed AI prototypes before a live jury at IIIT Pune, demonstrating technical complexity, creativity, and real-world relevance.

The successful execution of Thinking Machine reinforces IIIT Pune's commitment to fostering a culture of innovation, applied research, and entrepreneurial problem-solving among its students and the wider academic community. The event sets a strong precedent for future editions of the hackathon.